Austria, most fiercely opposed the creation of a third, Slavic unit (in addition to the Austrian and Hungarian ones) in the Austro-Hungarian Empire, fearful of reducing their bargaining power versus the Austrians. Finally, the end of World War I saw Hungarian territory, in accordance with the Treaty of Trianon, reduced to a third of its pre-war size, including sizable portions of its ethnic Hungarian areas. Such was the scale of this loss, that it continues to be the cause of national mourning 100 years later – and at the same time something that Mr Orbán can still use to rally support. I shall return to this topic later.

With such an eloquent history, Hungary stands out among the nations of Eastern Europe as probably the one that has had its own sovereign state for the longest time. Of course, this state took different forms and shapes over the centuries, and periods of sovereign rule were interrupted by shorter or longer periods of foreign domination, but overall Hungarians have the strongest tradition of statehood in the region. They are followed closely by the Poles. Croats and Serbs had powerful early medieval kingdoms which later disappeared. Serbs and Bulgarians only regained independence in the nineteenth century, as did the Greeks. Czechs finally lost their independence to Habsburgs in the seventeenth century. Most of Eastern Europe, as we shall see later, only fully regained its independence in the early twentieth century, as a result of the break-up of either the Ottoman Empire or Austria-Hungary. Indeed, for Central Europe, the experience of the Austro-Hungarian Empire, lasting 500 years, was central and has decisively shaped the region's political, social and cultural history. Its long endurance was another reason for the absence of any major conflict among the peoples of Eastern Europe.

But there *was* a major conflict involving the nations of Eastern Europe – the one with the Ottoman Empire. The arrival of Ottomans and their long-lasting rule in South-Eastern Europe was actually the second event after the Christian schism between the Orthodox and Catholic Church to alter the shape of Eastern Europe, creating another, third tier in the region – the Balkans. Central Europe was affected too: while busy fending off the occasional Ottoman inroads, it was unable to make a fuller grasp of the Renaissance. The Byzantine Empire, the Orthodox part of Eastern Europe, played the key role in this conflict; it also created a special bond with Slavic peoples, and this is why I turn to it next.